Behind The Mask: Geriatric Physical Therapy Career Guide 🚲

From Episode 2: Step By Step: Geriatric Physical Therapy with **Dr. Ariel Stoner**

What is this career?
Definition: a licensed healthcare professional who specializes in preventing, evaluating, and treating age-related conditions, movement dysfunctions, and physical injuries in older adults

What do they do?
"Geriatric physical therapists see residents who live in the assisted living facility, and we see members of the community who just come from the neighborhood, all 55 and older. And then we also see participants in an adult daycare. It's a medical model, so the participants are all people who have medical diagnoses where it's hard for them to be at home during the day, and it's to kind of give their caregivers a break. So they come and they get the medical support that they need, but they also get entertainment and things like that. When they have physical therapy needs, we'll see them at our location as well. "

Education pathway
"So I did a 3+3 program. I actually applied to physical therapy in high school, kind of crazy. I picked what I wanted to do and kind of stuck with it. So when I was in my senior year of high school, I applied to a program called Touro in New York City where they have a special honors program where if you know that this is what you wanna do, you can apply and you have an interview. And basically, if you maintain a certain GPA in your undergrad, they automatically accept you into their graduate program. You still have to go through the application process, but you're guaranteed acceptance once you're accepted into the program. So I did three years of undergrad, and then I started my three years of grad school."

Licensures/certifications
Required:

- National Physical Therapy Examination (NPTE)
- State Physical Therapy License
- **Optional: Specialized Certification

Skills needed

- Communication, Patience, and Empathy
- Clinical Assessment
- Problem-Solving
- Physical Stamina
- Attention to Detail
- Motivation and Encouragement
- Teamwork

Challenges faced
"Not to get technical, but you know, the way that insurance pays us back for our work is a bit of a challenge right now. So, the rates are getting cut, so that means we have to see more people to hit our

worth in terms of when you're working for somebody else and they're paying your salary, you have to have a certain productivity for it to be worth it to them to continue, you know, doing what they're doing."

Career progression ability
Entry-Level Physical Therapist → Experienced Geriatric Physical Therapist → **optional*** Geriatric Clinical Specialist (Board-Certified)*→ Clinical Supervisor or Director → Advanced Career Opportunities (teaching, research, private practice, healthcare administration)

Related careers
1. *Occupational Therapist* - helps patients move independently through everyday activities
2. *Physical Therapy Assistant (PTA)* - works with physical therapists to provide rehab and therapeutic exercises
3. *Speech-Language Pathologist* - helps older adults with communication and swallowing
4. *Geratric Nurse* - provides care and support to older adults
5. *Orthopedic Physical Therapist* - focuses on movement and rehabilitation for musculoskeletal conditions

Advice from Dr. Stoner
"I would just say that any career in healthcare is hard work. You're dealing with people all day, every day, and it's not when they're at their best. They're in pain, they're suffering, and they're often not super excited to be where they're at. So you have to come into a career in healthcare looking at it as something that you really wanna do and it's, and it's something that you really feel passionate about. And with that positivity and that personability to help people when they're not at their best."

Podcast episode
Season 2, Episode 2: **Step By Step: Geriatric Physical Therapy with Dr. Stoner**